Meltingly soft onions make a flavorful base for this lightly spiced soup enriched with almonds and sweetened with a hint of caramel.

onion and almond soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS, PLUS 2 HOURS SALTING **COOK** 1 HR **FREEZE** UP TO 2 MONTHS BEFORE HALF-AND-HALF IS ADDED

1 onion, very finely sliced
½ tsp sea salt
vegetable oil, to deep-fry
3½oz (100g) almonds (with skins on)
3¼ cups hot chicken stock
4 tbsp butter
¼ tsp nigella seeds
4 large onions, diced
1 red chile, chopped
1 tsp dark brown (muscovado) sugar
2 tbsp balsamic vinegar
½ cup half-and-half
salt and freshly ground black pepper

1 For a fried onion garnish, put the onion slices in a shallow dish, sprinkle with the sea salt, then set to one side for at least 2 hours. Using your hands, squeeze out the liquid, then pat dry with paper towels. Deep-fry in hot oil for 1–2 minutes or until golden, then drain on paper towels.

2 Bring a small pan of water to a boil, add the almonds, turn off the heat, and cover with a lid. Let soak for 15 minutes, then drain and slip off the skins once the nuts are cool enough to handle. Transfer to a food processor with ½ cup of the stock, then process to a paste and set aside.

3 Meanwhile, melt the butter in a large pan, add the nigella seeds, and cook over low heat for 1 minute. Stir in the diced onions and chile, cover, and cook over very low heat for 20–30 minutes or until soft but not brown, then turn up the heat and remove the lid. When the onions begin to turn golden in color, stir in the sugar and cook until it starts sticking to the bottom of the pan. Add the vinegar and continue cooking until sticky.

4 Add the rest of the stock and the almond paste and simmer for 20 minutes. Process the soup until smooth in a blender, then return to the pan, stir in the cream, and season with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Reheat gently and serve garnished with the fried onions.